

THE WOMAN

breasts round and hard like chariot wheels, biceps like young paw paws. Wonderful.

I also see the new breed when I am out jogging. They are all tall. Hells bells, it is amazing how big they grow females these times. They have big shoulders, they wear tiny shorts, often two colours, red on the left, blue on the right, legs so long they seem to go up to the shoulders with beaut calves . . . And remember how girls used to run in our day? They used to do a pretty waddle with hands dancing from side to side.

All right. You see these girls going round Melbourne's Botanic Gardens and it is a curious thing. The new breed is captivated by this athleticism; there are more females than males.

The way they run is beyond belief. No waddle, they stride. One morning early I thought I would match it with one of them, a splendid 185 centimetre Boadicea of a brunette. Alas, she went past me with the speed of a space shuttle.

Now, Martina Navratilova symbolises all this modern athletic wonder. Admittedly there are some things about her that distress me. If she is going to carry me off under her arm I would like her to grow her hair down her back. Those Victa mower blonde hair styles simply won't do. Nor do I approve of her indifference to fashion, those little wrap-around skirts and those awful shorts. If she could borrow some of the styles of Chrissie Evert I would be happy.

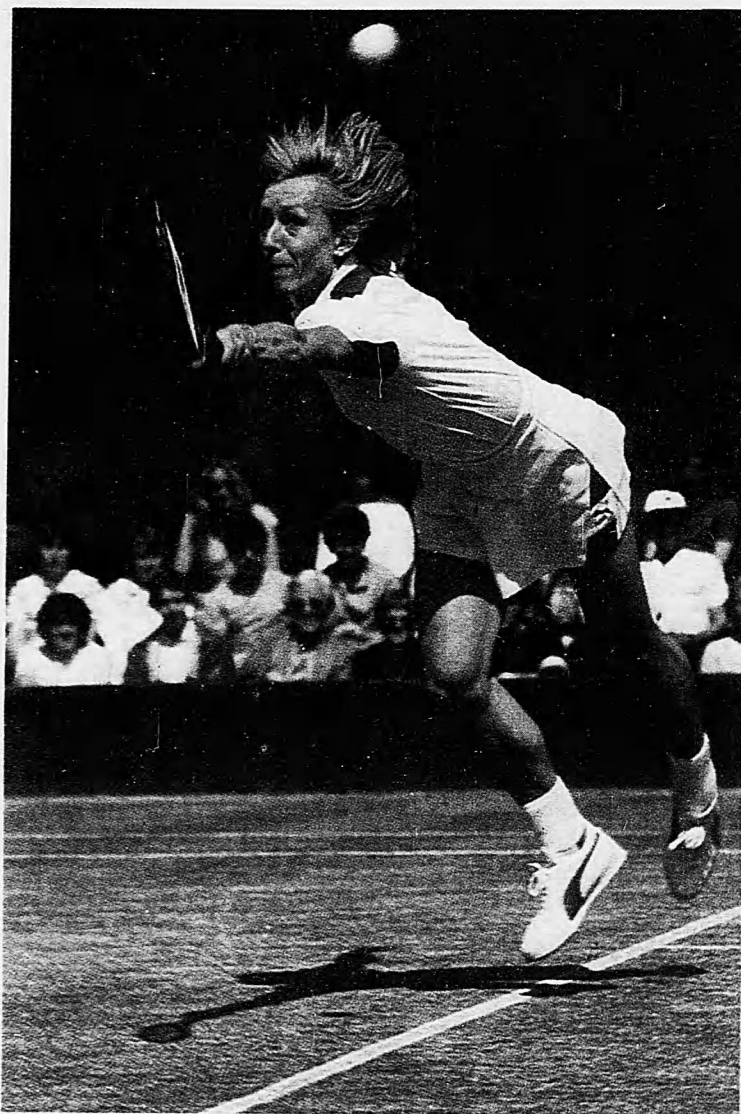
But sometimes when I need inspiration I go to the photographic library and take down the Navratilova file. Wheee, here you find really something.

There is one photograph that comes up again and again. It shows Martina stretching for a forehand drive, knee bent and her mighty left arm reaching almost to the camera lens. Obviously photographers are as devoted to that arm as I am. One could only describe it as an ultimate weapon of power.

Her biceps brachii is a noble mound and when it is truly flexed there is a lovely vein that comes up like a piece of electrical wiring. Ah, but all those muscles on her forearm, the extensor carpi ulnaris, the elegant extensor digitorum, to say nothing of her brachioradialis and her extensor carpi radialis brevis, are something to behold.

As for her legs, I stand back in adoration. Look at those upper thigh muscles, the splendid adductor magnus, the noble rectus femoris and when you get down around the calves how could any photographer resist her tibialis anterior.

Hana Mandlikova said some very unkind things about Martina during this



Navratilova: mighty left arm reaching almost to the camera

year's Wimbledon. One quote comes to mind: "I don't respect Martina for her achievement. When you see how she looks now, I think people should be asking the doctors how she got that way."

The truth is that Hana has not worked hard enough at her weight-lifting, her serious iron pumping, and she wishes that she had a biceps brachii or even a triceps brachii to match Martina's.

There is one aspect about her that is a little disturbing. She is advised by Dr Robert Haas who keeps her on a peak performance diet, which rules out all dairy products, all red meats, all eggs, sugars and sauces. Not for her any hamburgers, chips or ice cream. After all, one does like to break out into an ice cream or a fried chip occasionally.

Then in the midst of all the controversy it was suggested that Martina should play the 100th male on the world computer rating. Alas, the

challenge was not accepted — and with good reason, Martina would swallow him like a Sydney oyster.

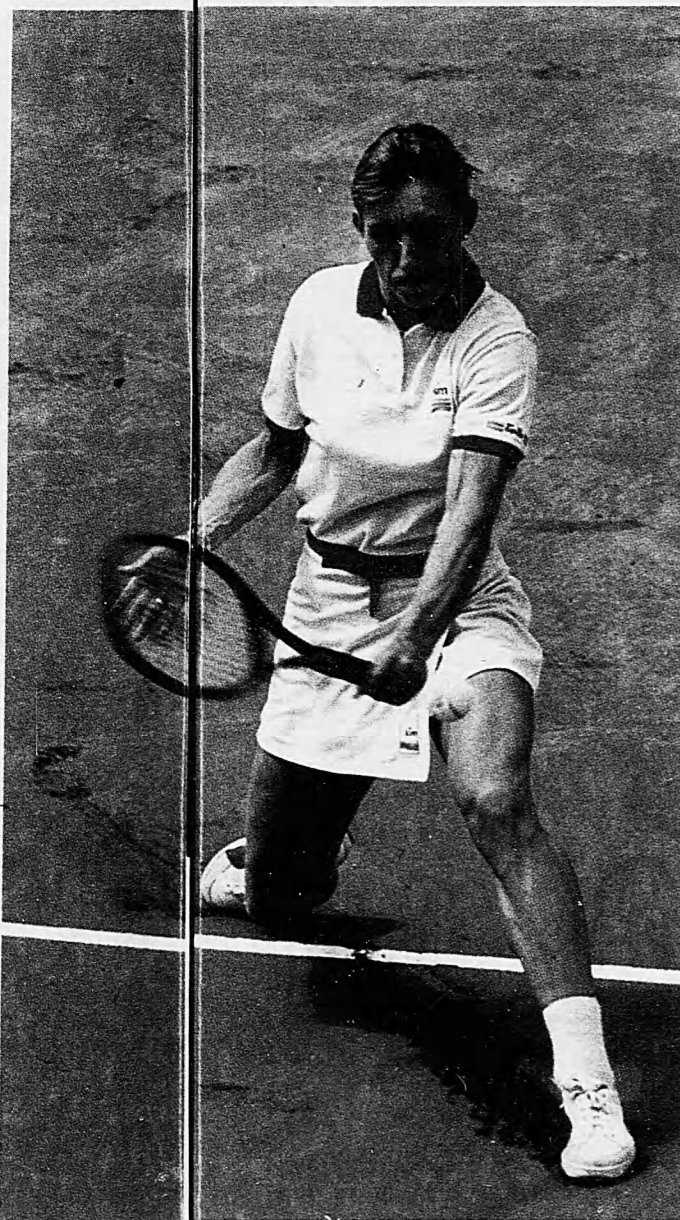
Ah, yes, to me Martina is the queen of the new upsurge of womanhood. No need to stand up in the tram for such a power lady. No need to open doors for her or carry her shopping baskets. Such deeds would put her biceps brachii out of training. She would be there to protect you or as a powerful ally when you walked the dog through the darkened park in the evening.

There was a time when my ideal female existed between the 15th and 18th centuries. I adored those lovely large Rubens females, or even better those magnificent Boticelli nudes. This was an era before diet, before bikinis, before sun tanning; everything was large, pure white and very round.

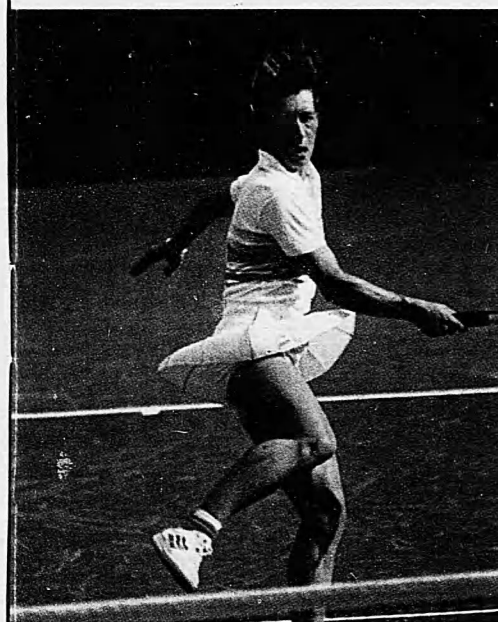
However, all that is behind me. I am into muscle and power.

Martina is superb. □

GOOD WEEKEND



Mike Estep worked on her backhand



Look at those thigh muscles . . .

GOOD WEEKEND

THE PERFORMER

fitness and technique has been not only recognised but also overcome, systematically and painstakingly.

For her efforts the 28-year-old former Czechoslovakian has been rewarded with unprecedented success, wealth and the dubious honour of being labelled a freak. This suggests, wrongly, that Navratilova's ability is in some way unnatural; that her victories are easier than those of others; that she has not been faced with difficulties in her climb to the top. In reality she is a top-class player who has evolved into a champion through her willingness to learn, adapt and work hard.

Such is Navratilova's dominance on the women's tennis circuit it is difficult to recall the years when she was regarded as a gifted but fallible player.

Only three years ago, Navratilova had a reputation not unlike Ivan Lendl's today. Talent and sheer power were enough to blast her into the finals of just about any tournament. But she was unpredictable under pressure, losing in semi-finals or finals 11 times in 1981.

Her arch-rival Chris Evert-Lloyd described Martina's problem as "emotional vulnerability." She was half-expected to collapse whenever a match started to go against her.

But in 1981 Navratilova met Nancy Lieberman, who was to be her motivational mentor for the next few years. Lieberman, a star from the fiercely-competitive US basketball scene, was horrified at Navratilova's lackadaisical approach to practice. The Czech sometimes would spend only half an hour on the court on free days.

Lieberman impressed on Navratilova the value of using practice sessions to increase concentration and develop mental sharpness. Under Lieberman's guidance, Navratilova learned to play using reason rather than instinct.

Having revitalised her mental approach to the game, Navratilova enlisted coach Dr Renee Richards to improve her technique. Richards took on a Navratilova just beaten in demoralising circumstances in the US Open final. She had let Tracy Austin back into the match after having her down match-point.

Navratilova believed she had lost the match for technical reasons. With Richards' help she remodelled her game by changing her forehand grip, improving her forehand volley and increasing her serving repertoire. Richards also had Navratilova work on a baseline game. It was a worthwhile exercise but it led to a dispute over playing style which split the pair during the French Open in 1983.

A few weeks later Mike Estep stepped in, first as a practice partner and then as

a coach. He put the emphasis back on Navratilova's net play, made a weapon of her back-hand return of serve and taught her the kicking serve.

Of all the myths and exaggerations surrounding Martina Navratilova those concerning her physique are probably believed most widely. Fellow Czech Hana Mandlikova started the "built like a man" theory.

"It's difficult to play against a man . . . I mean against Martina," Mandlikova complained at a press conference following a loss to her former countrywoman at the French Open this year. "She comes to the net to scare me and with those big muscles and being so big she is hard to pass."

Mandlikova's imagery is slightly overdone. Navratilova is a trim size 10 and works hard to maintain that figure. Her fitness program includes road-running, sprint work, weight training, exercises (including 100 sit-ups every day) as well as up to six hours a day on court.

Having exercised and dieted her way to a firm, fit figure, Navratilova understandably gets peeved at suggestions that she is beefy or built like a man.

Still, she should be used to it. For perfecting her mental attitude to tennis she is described as a computer. For perfecting her technique she is labelled a machine. For perfecting her fitness she is accused of being masculine.

But she retains a sense of humour about discrepancies between reputation and reality. Her favourite pet is a chihuahua named Killer Dog. □

*Earlier this year, Debbie Spillane joined the ABC as its first woman sports commentator. She is a former grade cricket umpire and also holds a Level I rugby league coaching certificate.



Martina today: an all-time great